theory of recapitulation" which states that the life history of an individual (ontogeny) briefly repeats or recapitulates the evolutionary history of the race (phylogeny). In other words **"Ontogeny recapitulates Phylogeny".** The embryonic stages of a higher animal resemble the adult stage of its ancestors. Appearance of pharyngeal gill slits, yolk sac and the appearance of tail in human embryos are some of the examples **(Fig. 6.4).** The biogenetic law is not universal and it is now thought that animals do not recapitulate the adult stage of any ancestors. The human embryo recapitulates the embryonic history and not the adult history of the organisms.

The comparative study of the embryo of different animals shows structural similarities among themselves. The embryos of fish, salamander, tortoise, chick and human start life as a single cell, the zygote, and undergo cleavage to produce the blastula, change to gastrula and are triploblastic. This indicates that all the above said animals have evolved from a common ancestor.

Molecular evidences

Molecular evolution is the process of change in the sequence composition of molecules such as DNA, RNA and proteins across generations. It uses principles of evolutionary biology and population genetics to explain patterns in the changes of molecules.

One of the most useful advancement in the development of molecular biology is proteins and other molecules that control life processes are conserved among species. A slight change that occurs over time in these conserved molecules (DNA, RNA and protein) are often called molecular clocks. Molecules that have been used to study evolution are cytochrome c (respiratory pathway) and rRNA (protein synthesis).

6.5 Theories of biological evolution

6.5.1 Lamarck's theory

Jean Baptiste de Lamarck, was the first to postulate the theory of evolution in his famous book '**Philosophie Zoologique**' in the year **1809**. The two principles of Lamarckian theory are:

i. The theory of use and disuse - Organs that are used often will increase in size and those that are not used will degenerate. Neck in giraffe is an example of use and absence of limbs in snakes is an example for disuse theory.

ii. The theory of inheritance of acquired characters - Characters that are developed during the life time of an organism are called acquired characters and these are then inherited.

The main objection to Lamarckism

Lamarck's "Theory of Acquired characters" was disproved by **August Weismann** who conducted experiments on mice for twenty generations by cutting their tails and breeding them. All mice born were with tail. Weismann proved his germplasm theory that change in the somatoplasm will not be transferred to the next generation but changes in the germplasm will be inherited.

Neo-Lamarckism

The followers of Lamarck (Neo-Lamarckists) like **Cope, Osborn, Packard** and **Spencer** tried to explain Lamarck's theory on a more scientific basis. They considered that adaptations are universal. Organisms acquire new structures due to their adaptations to the changed environmental conditions. They argued that external conditions stimulate the somatic cells to produce certain 'secretions' which reach the sex cells through the blood and bring about variations in the offspring.

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